



TripCanvas · PM-06 · Portfolio Case Study

Product Strategy · Discovery · MVP

TripCanvas

A Decision Workspace for Pre-Booking Travel Planning

How I identified a comparison gap in travel planning,
defined the product strategy, and built a working MVP.

BUILT BY

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CASE ID

PM-06

PHASE GATE

MVP Complete 

DOMAIN

Consumer Travel Tech

Case Structure

Roadmap

- **I Situation** Slides 3–4
- **II Discovery & Evidence** Slides 5–6
- **III Problem Definition** Slide 7
- **IV Strategy & Non-Goals** Slide 8
- **V Solution & Architecture** Slides 9–10
- **VI MVP & Success Metrics** Slides 11–12
- **VII Synthesis & Learning** Slide 13

The Central Thesis

During the pre-booking window, the trip organizer becomes the coordination layer across multiple travel platforms.

My research pointed to a gap in how unfinished options are compared across vendors.

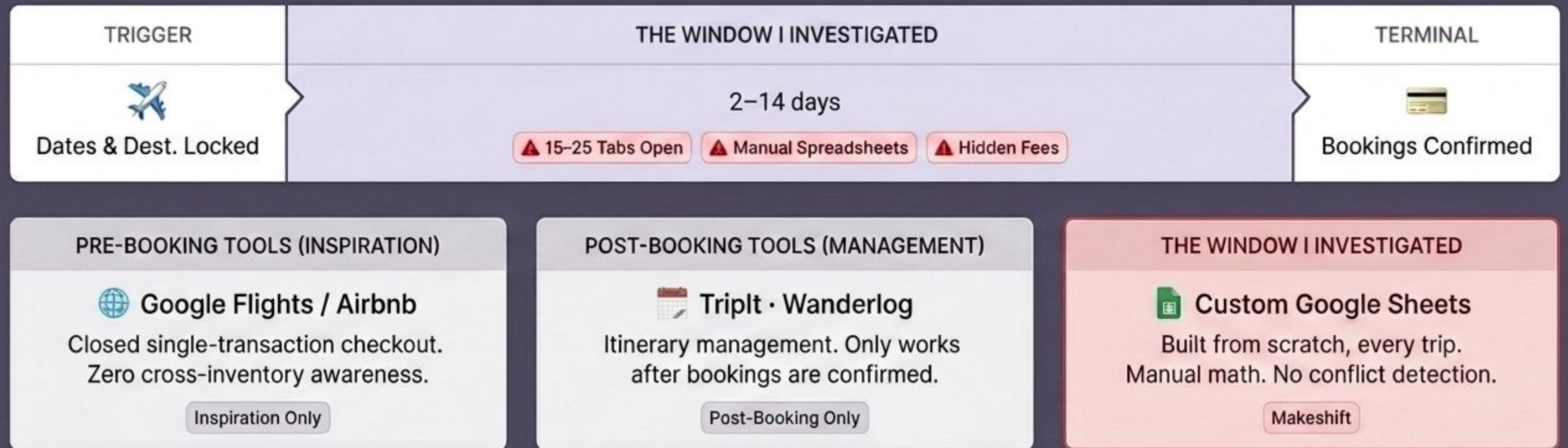
TripCanvas is designed around that gap.

CASE SCOPE

- ✓ Problem discovery & research
- ✓ Product strategy & non-goals
- ✓ Architecture trade-offs
- ✓ MVP & product requirements
- ✓ Working prototype

A gap appears between trip selection and booking

What happens between “we know where we’re going” and “the booking is confirmed”?



The gap I investigated: Existing tools handle discovery or post-booking management, but the comparison step between them often falls back to manual coordination.

The Lead Organizer: the person who ends up coordinating the trip



The Lead Trip Organizer

Primary User · Independent Leisure Travel

- **Trigger:** Destination and dates are fixed. Booking and budgeting begin.
- **Job:** Research, compare, budget, and drive a group to booking consensus — alone.
- **Planning window:** 2–14 days of comparison and coordination across 15–25 browser tabs.

CALLOUT BOX

Explicitly excluded: Corporate travel bookers, passive co-travelers, and top-of-funnel daydreamers who don't know where they're going yet.

How they manage it today



Google Sheets with pros/cons



Built from scratch, every single trip. Manual transcription of prices, dates, and fees.



Mental buffer margins



Organizers add +15–20% to every price to absorb unknown checkout fees. Pure guesswork.



Dictator with guardrails hack



Sets budget limits upfront and books autonomously — can't wait for group chat consensus.



Apple Notes link dumps



Raw links with no context, no costs, no comparisons. Shared to group chat and forgotten.

Common pattern: The organizer becomes the integration layer between otherwise disconnected tools.

Three evidence sources pointed toward the same breakdown

Personal workflow audit + qualitative interviews + community discourse

Source 1: Personal Deep Dive

Personal workflow audit views about this and sociation and comparison prevention: rerroder usual or own the cetotext optionemingation for unfinished travel options.

Source 2: Peer Interviews

The company problem was with interviews and appearly understard reveruls anding other ttransenitization options late travel site options to meanpart of travel options.

Source 3: Community Discourse

Community discourse are controtting the entinrment of groupsforeistact/notus, and more manertic other control overviant when it's manation for travel.

4 problem branches investigated

Periool reapervision and competition

Very High

Unfinished travel conel options

Core / root gap

Durciplate antemented auto options

Secondary

Can't spend and under seneriity

Secondary

Key insight

The strongest problem signal was the **lack of a shared comparison layer for unfinished travel options**. It appeared to sit underneath several of the other observed workarounds.

4 ways people work around the problem

People had already developed workarounds before TripCanvas existed.



The Dominant Expense Anchor

Organizers anchor planning around the biggest single cost. Flights for long trips; accommodation for weekend getaways. Everything else must absorb the trade-off. No tool shows this interdependency.

"Flights locked first because prices are volatile. Hotels are more stable."



The In-Trip Shock Absorber

When bookings cost more than expected, travelers don't cancel. They cut food, tours, and activities during the trip. Hidden checkout fees literally steal from the vacation experience.

"₹5,000 in unexpected fees → ₹5,000 cut from restaurants during the trip."



The Makeshift Comparison Matrix

No booking site allows multi-vendor side-by-side comparison with true costs. Organizers build custom spreadsheets from scratch for every trip — then rebuild them next trip, from scratch again.



The Guardrail Delegation Pattern

Waiting for group chat consensus causes prices to spike and rooms to sell out. Experienced organizers set upfront budget limits (max ₹5K/night) and book autonomously without approval loops.

Pattern across the four: people are already building their own comparison, budgeting, and coordination systems.

III · Problem Definition

The evidence supported a specific, measurable problem

Here is what I chose to solve.

OFFICIAL PROBLEM STATEMENT · GATE 5 LOCKED

For the **lead trip organizer** in the pre-booking phase (after dates and destination are decided), evaluating multi-item travel choices is an **exhausting, trial-and-error chore** because booking platforms operate in **isolated vertical silos** that hide **true checkout costs** and prevent **side-by-side trade-off comparison** between flights, stays, and arrival schedules, resulting in **hours of manual spreadsheet work**, high cognitive fatigue, and **unexpected checkout price creep** that forces travelers into **spending cutbacks during their vacation**.

ESTIMATED MANUAL COMPARISON TIME

3–10h / trip

ESTIMATED UNEXPECTED-FEE EXPOSURE

₹8–24K / trip

OBSERVED BROWSER TABS

15–25

Observed = workflow evidence.
Estimated = directional estimate,
not measured population data.

Own the decision layer above the OTA ecosystem — not the transaction layer

The strategy is deliberately narrow: focus on the pre-booking evaluation window and avoid owning the transaction itself.

PRODUCT THESIS · GATE 6

"If we give lead organizers a lightweight way to compare unfinished travel options, calculate true basket costs, and surface important conflicts, they can make booking decisions with less manual coordination."

3 CORE PRODUCT PRINCIPLES



Beat Google Sheets on Intelligence, Match on Speed

If adding an option takes >5 seconds, users abandon it and return to a blank spreadsheet.



True Total Basket Visibility

Never show a naked headline price. Always surface hidden fees, taxes, and transit costs upfront.



Speculative-First Design

Support unfinished what-if bundles. Never require that bookings already be finalized.

3 EXPLICIT STRATEGIC NON-GOALS



Not a Booking Engine / OTA

No payments, ticketing, or GDS integrations. When the user decides, we deep-link to the merchant. Competing with Expedia on price is a losing battle we've strategically declined.



Not a Day-by-Day Itinerary Scheduler

Once bookings are confirmed, Calendar and Wanderlog already work fine. Our focus stops at the transaction decision point — not one step beyond.



Not a Destination Discovery Engine

We don't tell users where to go or generate AI bucket lists. We only operate once destination and dates are already known. Top-of-funnel is out of scope by design.

The architecture trade-off

Approach	Strength	Risk	Decision
Browser Extension Capture	Strength Captures options where users discover them	Risk DOM brittleness + install friction	Rejected
Aggregator API	Strength Centralized structured data	Risk OTA dependency + API/licensing cost	Rejected
H – Hybrid ✓	Strength preserves manual flexibility while adding structured comparison	Trade-off some capture friction remains	Selected

Why Hybrid?

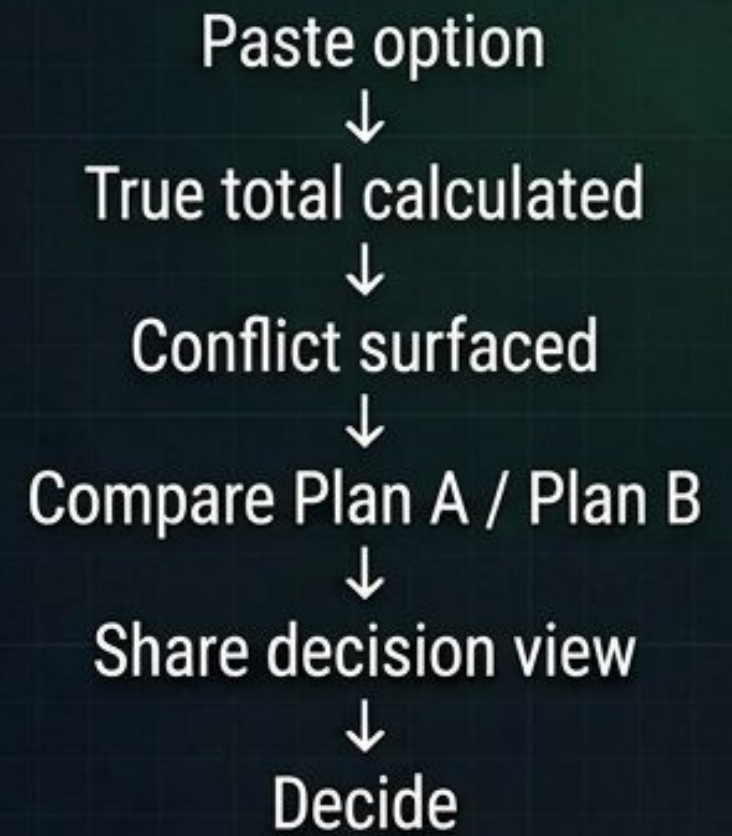
It fits the problem while preserving the strategic constraint of staying out of the transaction layer.

How TripCanvas changes the planning workflow

BEFORE



TRIPCANVAS



The product response maps directly to the problem:

Workspace Anchor

Keeps trip context together

Domain Engine

Calculates vendor-specific costs

Conflict Engine

Surfaces schedule conflicts

Canvas + Share

Supports side-by-side comparison and group decision-making

The MVP tests the core hypothesis with deliberately narrow scope

CORE HYPOTHESIS UNDER TEST

If lead organizers can capture options in under 60 seconds, see the true all-in basket cost, and receive automated conflict warnings — all without logging in — they will use TripCanvas instead of a blank Google Sheet.

MUST-HAVE USER STORIES (MVP)

Must	Paste an Airbnb/Airline link and see the true cost — including hidden fees — without doing math manually.
Must	Drag candidate options into Plan A / Plan B to compare them side-by-side without opening a spreadsheet.
Must	Be warned if flight arrives hours before hotel check-in so I don't get stranded with luggage for half a day.
Must	Share a read-only visual summary with my group so they can vote without digging through 20 separate links.

EXPLICITLY OUT OF SCOPE

Live OTA Scraping

Too brittle. Silent failures break the promise of cost accuracy.

User Accounts / Cloud Sync

localStorage suffices. No auth needed to test the hypothesis.

Browser Extension Clipper

Phase 1b. Dashboard alone tests the calculation hypothesis.

Booking Engine / Payments

Strategic non-goal. Decision layer, not transaction layer.

PROPOSED MVP SUCCESS CONDITION

Target: >60%
Bundle Comparison Completion Rate in moderated usability testing
Target: ≥4/5
Trustworthiness of True Total

Targets are proposed validation criteria, not measured

How I would measure whether the MVP works

This is much better for a PM deck than: “A single North Star metric with a built-in viral loop that funds organic distribution.”

★ NORTH STAR METRIC

Bundle Comparison Completion Rate

% of initiated trips that reach a completed side-by-side comparison.

Proposed target: >60%

⚡ SUPPORTING METRICS

Card Intake Speed

Proposed target: <30 sec

Share Link Generation Rate

Proposed target: >50%

⚠ GUARDRAILS

Manual Price Override Rate

Proposed target: <40%

Pre-Card Session Abandonment

Proposed target: <20%

3 decisions that shaped the product

The decisions I'm most proud of, the risks I navigated, and the PM muscle this case study was designed to build.

Decision 1: Rejected the browser extension as the core product

Why: DOM brittleness made it too fragile as the primary workflow.

Decision 2: Accepted some user friction to avoid OTA API dependency

Why: A manual URL-first flow was more compatible with the MVP's constraints.

Decision 3: Used non-goals to protect the strategy

Why: Avoiding booking, itinerary scheduling, and destination discovery kept the product focused.

What I learned

1. The workflow mattered more than the feature idea.
2. A strategic non-goal can be as important as a product requirement.
3. The cheapest technical path was not automatically the right product path.

What I'd do next

Run moderated usability tests with real trip organizers and measure whether TripCanvas improves comparison completion and reduces manual cross-referencing.

Project at a glance

- 13 project phases documented
- 4 behavioral patterns from research
- 3 architectures evaluated
- 1 selected product direction
- 0 backend servers required for MVP